Dubai population jumps from 12,000 to 4.58 million in 144 years

New real-time census shows emirate added 332,000 residents in 2025

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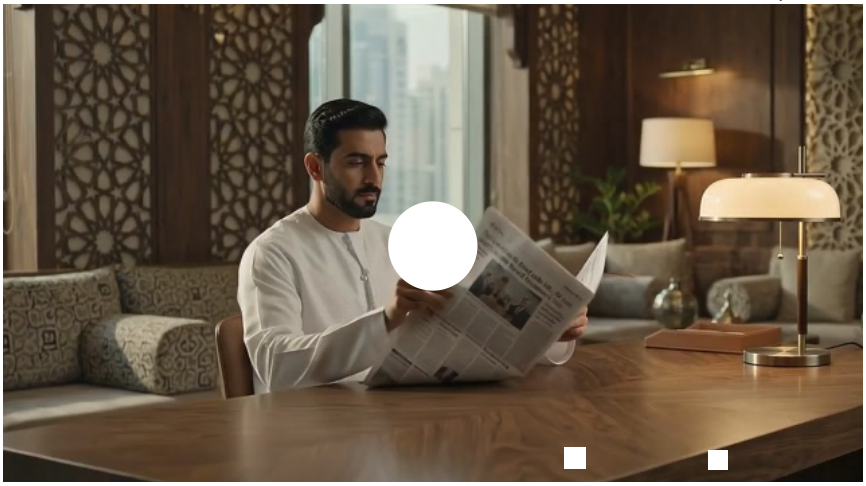
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Dubai: Dubai's resident population has surged past 4.58 million, marking one of the fastest annual increases in the emirate's history as authorities unveiled a groundbreaking AI-powered real-time population monitoring system that will transform urban planning and policymaking.

While the resident population stands at 4.58 million, the number of people physically present in the emirate during peak daytime hours climbs to 6.392 million, driven by workers, tourists, students, shoppers and other short-term visitors. More than 1.812 million people are temporarily present in Dubai on an average day, highlighting the enormous demand placed on roads, public

transport, utilities, healthcare and other essential services.

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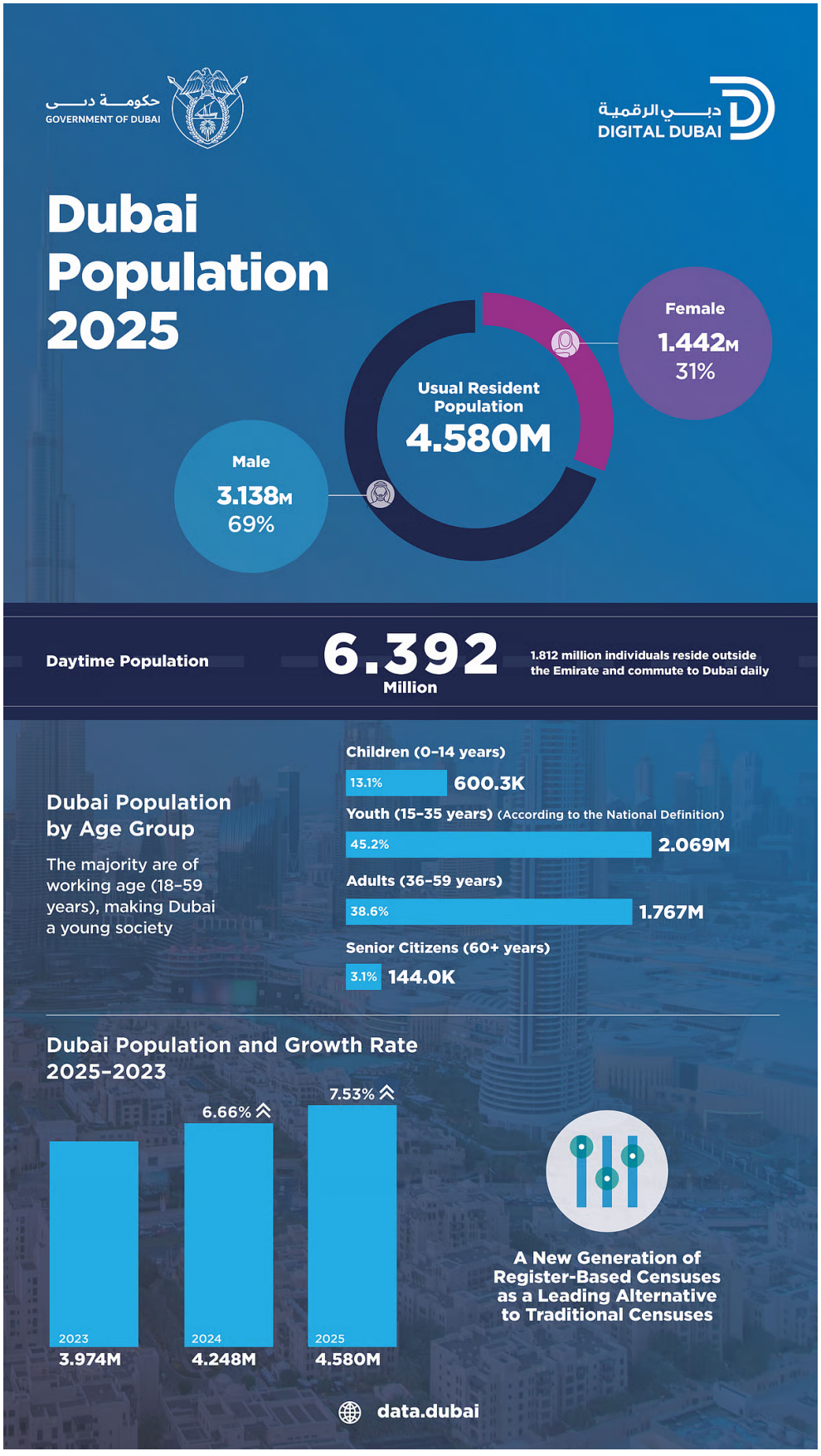
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Big increase

Digital Dubai announced that the emirate's resident population reached 4.580 million by the end of 2025, an increase of approximately 332,000 people over the previous year, representing a 7.5 per cent growth rate. The figures are generated using administrative records, smart government systems and advanced digital technologies rather than conventional census surveys.

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The initiative also provides a more realistic picture of Dubai's daily population.

Hamad Obaid Al Mansoori, Director General of Dubai Digital, described the initiative as a major milestone in Dubai's ambition to become a global leader in digital government.

He said the project reflects Dubai's vision of using advanced technologies to build an integrated digital ecosystem powered by trusted real-time data, enabling government entities to formulate more accurate policies, provide proactive services, improve investment decisions and strengthen the emirate's readiness for sustained growth.

Economic momentum

Younus Al Nasser, Chief Executive Officer of the Dubai Data and Statistics Establishment, said the population figures mirror Dubai's strong economic momentum and growing international attractiveness.

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The emirate recorded 5.4 per cent GDP growth in 2025, welcomed 19.6 million

international tourists, up 5 per cent, while Dubai Airports handled around 96 million passengers, an increase of 4.9 per cent over the previous year. Population growth, he said, reflects the expansion of the labour market, rising demand for services and continuous improvements in quality of life.

Officials said the new register-based methodology represents the next generation of population censuses. Instead of conducting a traditional census every few years, the system continuously integrates data from government entities, linking administrative records through secure digital platforms.

How it is calculated

Artificial intelligence, machine learning and predictive analytics are used to analyse demographic trends, forecast future population movements and support planning for housing, education, healthcare, transportation and other public services. The data also powers Dubai's real-time Population Clock, allowing policymakers to monitor demographic changes as they happen.

The initiative is the result of collaboration among several government entities, including the General Directorate of Residency and Foreigners Affairs (GDRFA), Roads and Transport Authority (RTA), Dubai Electricity and Water Authority

(DEWA), Dubai Health Authority (DHA), Dubai Municipality, Dubai Land Department, Knowledge and Human Development Authority (KHDA), Dubai Department of Economy and Tourism (DET), and Dubai Government Human Resources Department.

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Fastest growing city

Officials said Dubai has become one of the fastest-growing cities among advanced economies, with its population growth underpinned by world-class infrastructure, business-friendly policies and its ability to attract global talent and investment. The new real-time monitoring system will help ensure infrastructure and public services keep pace with the emirate's rapid expansion.

Key numbers at a glance

- Resident population (End-2025): 4.580 million
- Resident population (End-2024): 4.248 million
- Residents added in 2025: 332,000
- Annual population growth: 7.5%
- Average daytime population: 6.392 million
- Temporary daytime population: 1.812 million

- Real GDP growth (2025): 5.4%
- International visitors (2025): 19.6 million (+5%)
- Airport passengers (2025): 96 million (+4.9%)

Dubai population through history

- 1881: Fewer than 12,000 residents
- 1975: First modern population census conducted
- 1980: Highest annual population growth recorded at 8.2%
- 2005: Last traditional population census
- End-2024: 4.248 million residents
- End-2025: 4.580 million residents
- Growth over 144 years: Nearly 380-fold increase in population

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Ashfaq has been storming the UAE media scene since 1997. His insights, analysis and deep understanding of regional dynamics have helped make sense of the unfolding news.

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